

Though the father's job has been restored, Rita still stitches to purchase "costly books for Suraj". Meanwhile Suraj, an erstwhile music buff, too has made his little sacrifices. He has refused to get his FM transistor radio repaired, and has stopped playing cricket.

Many of these boys may well have benefited from the OBC quota system, which the UPA Government introduced in 2008 as part of their affirmative action policy. The quota system came into effect after the Supreme Court in April last year upheld 27 per cent reservation for the OBCs in Central educational institutions while excluding the creamy layer from it. Records suggest that the decision had a positive impact on the number of OBC aspirants for an IIT seat. This year 1,04,045 OBC candidates took the examination while the number of such candidates was less than 50,000 in 2007. This year, as many as 1,930 candidates have been shortlisted to get into premier technical colleges.

Selection in the OBC category is made by relaxing the entry bar by 10 per cent. While many of these students like Rahul have qualified in the overall merit list too, the reservation advantage may help them get into a better institute. The quota system, however, was surely not the driving force. "Their extraordinary success has nothing to do with their poverty or the quota system. It suggests their inner resolve which made them forget the surroundings and go beyond



VISHWARAJ ANAND, 17

OBC RANK 1,305

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His father is unemployed and mother a homemaker. The family has leased three rooms of their flat for Rs 3,000 which is their only source of household income. But these adversities have not deterred Vishwaraj from achieving big. He made his family proud by clearing the entrance exam in his first attempt.

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ALOK KUMAR, 18

RANK 6,636

His elder brother's muscular disorder made it even more imperative for the 18-year-old to do something worthy in life and rescue his family from the clutches of poverty. His father, a small-time lawyer, had to often borrow money to meet his son's study expenses.